



ECHUNGA
FAMILY CHURCH

MEMBERSHIP & DISCIPLESHIP

On the Way with Jesus

Grace, Discipleship and Belonging at
Echunga Family Church

OUR VISION

A New Generation Finding Jesus and His People in the Adelaide Hills
and Beyond.

1 Two people this is written for

The first has been part of this church for a very long time. You have worshipped here, buried your parents from this building, made the sandwiches, mown the lawns, sat through more meetings than anyone should have to. If someone asked whether you were a member, you would probably say yes without thinking about it — and that's great! But what does church membership really mean?

The second arrived in recent months or years. You are finding your way, working out whether this is home, aware that there is a language here you have not yet learned.

This document is for both of you, and it is not really about paperwork. It is an attempt to say what it means to belong to the people of God in this place, and why the Uniting Church talks about membership the way it does. If at the end of it you find yourself wanting to take a step, there is one to take. If you simply understand your own baptism better than you did, that is worth the reading on its own.

2 Grace goes first

Everything here rests on something that was true before you thought about it.

For by grace you have been saved through faith, and this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God — not the result of works, so that no one may boast.

☞ **EPHESIANS 2:8-9**

The Basis of Union, the founding document of the Uniting Church, puts it as bluntly as Paul does: “The whole work of salvation is effected by the sovereign grace of God alone.”

That sentence should be read slowly, because a great deal follows from it. It means that nothing in this document is a bar to clear or a standard to meet. God is not waiting to see how you go. Jesus said to his friends, “You did not choose me but I chose you” (John 15:16), and the same priority runs through everything that follows: God acts first, and we respond.

But grace being free is not the same as grace leaving us unchanged. Dallas Willard’s phrase is the one I keep coming back to: “grace is opposed to earning, but it is not opposed to effort.” An apple tree does not strain to produce apples. It does need light, water, soil and time. In the same way, a life growing in the grace of God is not a life of gritted teeth, but neither is it a life of drift. There are things that help, and this is an attempt to name them honestly.

3 The church is not an organisation you join

We reach for the wrong picture almost automatically. We think of membership the way we think of the golf club or the CWA: an association of individuals who have signed up, paid their dues, and may leave when it no longer suits.

The New Testament does not have that picture anywhere. It has a body, a household, a flock, a temple, a family — images in which belonging is not an administrative arrangement but the thing itself. “Now you are the body of Christ and individually members of it” (1 Corinthians 12:27). Paul’s word for member is the word for a limb. You are not a subscriber to the body. You are a hand.

The Basis of Union describes the church’s calling this way:

“to be a fellowship of reconciliation, a body within which the diverse gifts of its members are used for the building up of the whole, an instrument through which Christ may work and bear witness to himself.”

 **BASIS OF UNION**

And then it adds the image that has shaped the Uniting Church’s self-understanding ever since: “the Church is a pilgrim people, always on the way towards a promised goal; here the Church does not have a continuing city but seeks one to come. On the way Christ feeds the Church with Word and Sacraments, and it has the gift of the Spirit in order that it may not lose the way.”

A pilgrim people. Not an institution maintaining itself, not a club of the like-minded, but a company of people travelling together who are fed along the road. That is what you are being invited into, and it is why we describe ourselves the way we do: a new generation finding Jesus and his people in the Adelaide Hills and beyond. Membership is simply the name the church gives to travelling with these particular people, in this particular place.

4 Always remember you are baptised

Here is where the Uniting Church may differ from what you have known elsewhere, and where the difference is worth understanding rather than merely accepting.

In some traditions, baptism is understood chiefly as something we do — the first act of obedience by which a believer publicly declares a decision already made. The Uniting Church confesses something prior to that. The Basis of Union says: “Christ incorporates people into his body by Baptism... Baptism into Christ's body initiates people into Christ's life and mission in the world, so that they are united in one fellowship of love, service, suffering and joy.”

Baptism, in other words, is first of all Christ's action, not ours. It is God's claim laid on a human life. That is why this church baptises both adults who confess the faith and children presented by their families, taking responsibility for their instruction and nourishment in the faith. In neither case is the water a reward for something achieved. In both cases it is a sign of a love that got there first.

One profession of faith, made once

Everyone is asked to profess faith in their own voice, once. What differs between us is only when that happens.

If you come to be baptised as an adult — or as a child old enough to answer for yourself — your profession is made at your baptism, and your baptism and confirmation are the same event. The Regulations are plain about it: a candidate for confirmation who has not been baptised “shall be baptised either prior to or in conjunction with the confirmation”. Nothing is held over for later.

If you were baptised as an infant, that profession was not yours to make. Your parents made theirs, and the church made its promises about your instruction and nourishment in the faith. Your own yes was always going to come later. Confirmation is where it is given.

So confirmation is not a second baptism, and not a senior grade of Christian. It is simply where the personal yes is spoken when it could not be spoken at the baptismal font.

Two signings

You can watch all of this happen in a single service. Everyone who comes forward is signed with the cross. Only the words change.

OVER SOMEONE JUST BAPTISED

“N, from this day on, the sign of the cross is upon you.”

OVER SOMEONE BEING CONFIRMED

“N, always remember you are baptised, and be thankful.”

The same gesture, made twice. One looks forward from today. The other looks back to a day you cannot remember and tells you that it still holds. Then hands are laid on — by the minister, and by elders appointed for the purpose — and prayer is made for the gifts of the Spirit.

Not become baptised. Remember it. Your baptism is not an event receding behind you; it is a standing fact about your life that you get to live into for as long as you live.

This is precisely what confirmation is. Uniting in Worship 2 names the rite “The Reaffirmation of Baptism called Confirmation”, and explains it in a single sentence worth memorising:

“Confirmation has two meanings: the Church confirms God's promises declared in baptism, and we affirm our willingness to live by that faith.”

 **UNITING IN WORSHIP 2**

Two movements, in that order. God's promises confirmed to you; your willingness affirmed in response. The Basis of Union says the Uniting Church will “seek ways in which the baptized may have confirmed to them the promises of God, and be led to deeper commitment to the faith and service into which they have been baptized.”

So confirmation is not a graduation ceremony for teenagers, and it is not a formality for getting onto a list. It is the moment a baptised person says, in front of everyone, yes — this is mine, and I will live in it. Many people who were baptised as infants and have never had that moment. It is still available. It is, in fact, exactly what it is for.

And if you have never been baptised at all — whatever your age — the invitation is simply to the beginning of the same road. There is no minimum age and no waiting list. There is a conversation, and then a Sunday. The companion booklet, Baptism and Confirmation, sets out what that looks like.

This is what we mean when we say we are here for a new generation finding Jesus and his people. A generation is not only the young, though it certainly includes them; it is everyone who has not yet heard their own name said over the water, and everyone who has heard it and never answered. Finding Jesus comes first, because in truth he is the one who finds us. Finding his people comes with it, because he has never yet saved anyone into solitude.

The shape of a life on the way

When someone is confirmed in this church, four questions are asked. They are not our invention, and they are not a high bar erected by the keen. They are what the whole church, everywhere, asks of everyone who says yes.

They also make a remarkably good description of a disciple's life, so we will take them one at a time.



AFFIRMATION ONE · WORSHIP

Will you continue in the community of faith, the apostles' teaching, the breaking of bread and the prayers?

They devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers.

📖 ACTS 2:42

Four things, and none of them optional extras.

The community of faith. Christianity has never been a solo pursuit. We have been formed by a culture that treats faith as a private arrangement between an individual and God, and church as an optional support service for it. The New Testament knows nothing of this. God's chosen method for growing you is other people — including the ones who irritate you, which is not an accident.

The apostles' teaching. The Basis of Union lays upon members “the serious duty of reading the Scriptures”. That phrase — serious duty — is not softened anywhere. We are not asked to admire the Bible; we are asked to read it, hear it preached, argue with it, and let it argue back.

The breaking of bread. At the Lord's Table something happens that the Uniting Church takes with great seriousness: “the risen Lord feeds his baptized people on their way to the final inheritance of the Kingdom”, and there we “grow together into Christ, are strengthened for their participation in the mission of Christ in the world, and rejoice in the foretaste of the Kingdom” (Basis of Union, 8). This is not a memorial service for a dead friend. It is food for pilgrims.

The prayers. Together and alone, in the words the church has given us and in our own honest, heartfelt and personal ones.



Worship

OUR COMMON LIFE · 1 OF 4

We will gather for worship as the ordinary rhythm of our week rather than as one option among many. We will read the Scriptures and let them shape us. We will come to the Table, and encourage one another to come. We will pray — individually and with others, and we will share life honestly enough with a few others that they know what to pray for.



AFFIRMATION TWO · WITNESS

Will you proclaim, by word and example,
the good news of God in Christ?

Word and example, in that order in the liturgy and inseparable in practice. A life of quiet integrity with nothing ever said leaves people guessing; words without a life to back them are noise.

The Basis of Union prays that the church “may be ready when occasion demands to confess the Lord in fresh words and deeds” — fresh, because the old formulas do not always reach people, and because Echunga in 2026 is not Galilee in 33AD or Geneva in 1500AD.

Most of us will never preach a sermon. All of us live somewhere — a workplace, a school gate, a street, a football club — where we are the only Christian some people actually know. That is not a burden laid on you; it is simply where you already are — and it is what “the Adelaide Hills and beyond” means in practice: not a territory to be won, but the ordinary places we are already standing.



Witness

OUR COMMON LIFE · 2 OF 4

We will pray regularly for people we know who do not yet know Christ. We will look for natural opportunities to speak of him without embarrassment or pressure. We will invite people — to our homes as readily as to church. And we will talk about our town and our neighbours with affection rather than disdain, and to build up and bless.



AFFIRMATION THREE · WELCOME

Will you seek Christ in all people, and love your neighbour as yourself?

This is the question that turns discipleship from an interior project into something with hands.

Like good stewards of the manifold grace of God, serve one another with whatever gift each of you has received.

📖 1 PETER 4:10

The Basis of Union has a sentence about gifts that is worth pinning up: “the one Spirit has endowed the members of Christ's Church with a diversity of gifts, and that there is no gift without its corresponding service: all ministries have a part in the ministry of Christ.”

No gift without its corresponding service. Whatever you have been given was given for someone else's sake. That includes ability and time, and it includes money — not because the church has bills, though it does, but because generosity is the shape God's own life takes towards us and we are being made like him. Much of this is best decided in advance rather than in the moment, since our good intentions are more reliable when we have planned for them.

Seeking Christ in all people also cuts the other way. It means the person in front of you — whom you 'judge' difficult, unimpressive, not our sort — is someone in whom Christ is to be sought. That is harder than volunteering.



Welcome

OUR COMMON LIFE · 3 OF 4

We will offer our gifts in the service of this church and this community rather than waiting to be asked. We will give financially in a planned and regular way, as an act of worship. We will look to offer hospitality to people at the edges of our life together, and go and sit with them.



AFFIRMATION FOUR · WHOLENESS

Will you strive for justice and peace and respect the dignity of every human being?

What does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?

📖 MICAH 6:8

Some traditions treat this as an add-on for the politically inclined. The Uniting Church does not, and neither does the rite: it is a baptismal promise, asked of everyone.

It is also a promise with a particular weight in this country. In 1994 the Assembly entered a covenantal relationship with the Uniting Aboriginal and Islander Christian Congress, and the Preamble to our Constitution tells the truth about why — that the uniting churches were “complicit in the injustice that resulted in many of the First Peoples being dispossessed from their land, their language, their culture and spirituality, becoming strangers in their own land.” We belong to a church that has said this out loud about itself. Striving for justice is not a cause we have adopted; it is part of our repentance.

Closer to home it looks like fair dealing, refusing to trade in contempt, noticing who is poor or lonely in a town where it is easy not to notice, and using whatever influence we have on behalf of people who have none.



Wholeness

OUR COMMON LIFE · 4 OF 4

We will treat every person as one who bears God's image, including those we disagree with. We will learn the history of this land and this church's part in it. We will act for justice where we actually have reach — in our dealings, our spending, our speech and our care for the vulnerable.

6 What we hold

The Uniting Church does not ask congregations to write their own statements of belief, and Echunga has not done so. We stand with the whole church, and our confession is not ours alone.

With Christians of every century we say the Apostles' Creed and the Nicene Creed — which is why, when you are confirmed, you are asked to affirm your faith in the words of the creed rather than in a form we have composed ourselves. You are joining something much older than this congregation.

With the Uniting Church we hold the Basis of Union, which confesses Jesus Christ as the one Lord on whom the church is built; receives the Scriptures of the Old and New Testaments as “unique prophetic and apostolic testimony, in which it hears the Word of God”; acknowledges the two sacraments of Baptism and the Lord's Supper as acts in which “Christ himself acts”; affirms the diversity of gifts given for service; and describes us as a pilgrim people who pray that God “will constantly correct that which is erroneous in its life”.

That last phrase is worth sitting with. We belong to a church that has written into its founding document the expectation that it will get things wrong and need correcting. That is not weakness. It is honesty, and it is a good deal safer than certainty.

7 What membership actually means here

Having said all that, the practical arrangements are simple, and it is better to be plain about them than to leave people guessing.

The Uniting Church keeps four rolls, and every one of them describes people who genuinely belong:

Baptised members

Everyone baptised who has not yet been confirmed. This includes our children, and it includes adults baptised long ago who have never made their own profession of faith. If that is you, you are already a member of Christ's church. What is missing is your yes, and confirmation is where it is given.

Confirmed members

Those who, being baptised, have affirmed the faith for themselves. The Constitution puts it plainly: a confirmed member is one “recognised as having affirmed the faith, and as sharing the right and responsibility of participation in the work and government of the Church.”

Members-in-association

Those who belong to another denomination, or hold membership in another Uniting Church congregation, while sharing fully in the life of this one. If you are Anglican or Catholic or Baptist by background and Echunga is now your church, this is very likely you. It is recognised by Church Council on application, and it is a real membership, not a consolation prize.

Adherents

Those who worship with us and share our life without being members. You are counted, you are welcome, you may serve on committees and speak at congregational meetings. Under the Regulations, adherents do not vote in elections — which is worth saying plainly now rather than discovering at a meeting.

Two honest notes. The first is that confirmed members and members-in-association carry responsibility as well as rights: they are the ones who elect elders and councillors, and only they can be elected. If you care how this church is led, that matters. The second is that none of this measures anyone's standing with God. A roll is a record of who is travelling with us, kept so that we know who we are and can care for one another properly. It is not a scorecard.

8 Where you might be now

- **You were baptised as a child, and never confirmed.** You may have assumed you were a member all along — many have. Christ's claim on you was laid down at the font and has never been withdrawn. What is on offer is the chance to answer it out loud. Come and have a conversation; there is no hurry and no embarrassment.
- **You were never baptised.** Then the invitation is to the beginning: to be claimed, named and welcomed. The Uniting Church has a process for adults called Becoming Disciples, which takes the time it takes — usually leading to baptism at Easter. Ask us about it.
- **You are a member somewhere else, or of another denomination.** You may be able to be recognised as a member-in-association, or to transfer. Either way it is a conversation rather than a form.
- **You have decided you would rather remain an adherent.** That is a real position honestly held, and you remain fully welcome here. But we would like to ask you, gently: what is it that holds you back? Sometimes the answer is a good one. Sometimes it is just that nobody ever asked.

9 The conversation to start

There is no application form attached to this document, and that is deliberate. The next step is not paperwork; it is a cup of tea or a coffee and an unhurried conversation about where you have come from and where you are.

What we hope for from those conversations is not a longer roll. It is the thing we have set ourselves to pray for and work towards — a new generation finding Jesus and his people in the Adelaide Hills and beyond — which only ever happens one unhurried conversation at a time, and usually because someone who already belongs thought to ask.

You have been baptised into the faith of Christ, and are called to the worship, witness and service of God in the power of the Holy Spirit.

Our common life — in summary

Not four separate programs, but one hope worked out four ways: a new generation finding Jesus and his people in the Adelaide Hills and beyond.



Worship. We will gather for worship, read the Scriptures, come to the Table, and pray — together and alone.



Witness. We will proclaim the good news of God in Christ by word and example, in the places we already are.



Welcome. We will offer our gifts, our time and our money in service, and seek Christ in every person we meet.



Wholeness. We will strive for justice and peace, and respect the dignity of every human being.

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Echunga Family Church is a member congregation of the Uniting Church of South Australia.

Scripture quotations are from the New Revised Standard Version. Quotations from the Basis of Union are from the 1992 edition; liturgical texts are from Uniting in Worship 2 (Uniting Church Assembly, 2005).